

Color Mixing

Achieving any color from the primaries

Color mixing is the practical skill that turns color theory into color action.

Understanding how paints mix (subtractive mixing) versus how light mixes (additive mixing) is fundamental to painting in any medium.

KEY CONCEPTS

Primary Colors

In traditional paint (subtractive): red, yellow, blue. In print/digital (additive/CMYK): cyan, magenta, yellow. All other colors can theoretically be mixed from the primaries — in practice, your specific primary pigments limit what you can achieve.

Secondary & Tertiary Colors

Secondary: orange (R+Y), green (Y+B), violet (B+R). Tertiary: the 6 colors between primaries and secondaries (red-orange, yellow-orange, yellow-green, blue-green, blue-violet, red-violet). These 12 form the standard color wheel.

Bias

Real pigments have a bias — they lean warm or cool. A warm red (cadmium) mixes differently than a cool red (alizarin crimson). For clean, vibrant secondaries: mix two primaries that lean toward each other (a warm yellow + a warm red = bright orange).

Mixing Darks

Avoid using black from the tube. Instead, mix darks from complements or from deep pigments (Prussian blue, burnt umber, dioxazine purple). Mixed darks have more life and color than tube black.

PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Mix a complete 12-color wheel from only 3 primary colors.
2. Mix 5 different neutral greys/browns using only complementary pairs.
3. Match 10 specific colors from a photograph using your primaries only.

FURTHER READING

■ **Proko – Color Mixing Basics**

<https://youtu.be/AZhO4VjQUPE>